

The Big Picture

Understanding relativism and why it matters.

A Teaching Card from the Deep Dive Podcast

Based on the book by Greg Koukl and Francis Beckwith

A deeper look at why relativism is so pervasive, where it leads, and how Christians can respond with clarity and confidence.



1 The Core Paradox



- Many people claim that truth and morality are relative (subjective), yet they still strongly criticize immorality, injustice, and incivility in society.
- We want to have our cake and eat it too — denying objective truth while acting as if some things are truly right or wrong.

“We claim there are no absolute truths, but we act as if some things are truly right or wrong.”

2 Where Relativism Rules



- Moral relativism is the unofficial creed of much of American culture, especially in education, law, and public policy.
- It shapes how students think, influences legal arguments, and affects cultural norms and government decisions.

Common Examples

- Education (schools and universities)
- Law (legal arguments and rights claims)
- Public policy (government decisions)
- Media and entertainment
- Workplace culture
- Everyday conversations

3 Why It Matters



- Relativism isn't just an academic debate — it's a lived experience.
- You'll encounter it in school, work, family conversations, and public discourse.
- Understanding it helps us navigate these situations with clarity, confidence, and love.

Real-World Impact

- Confusion about what is right and wrong
- Inconsistency in our culture
- Erosion of moral standards
- Marginalization of those who disagree
- A society that talks past each other
- Harder to discipline and make a case for truth



“Be ready to give an answer to everyone who asks you to give the reason for the hope that you have ...”

1 Peter 3:15

Think Clearly
Ask Deeply
Live Wisely

Three Forms of Relativism

Same destination. Different roads.

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All roads seem right when there is no ultimate Truth.

1 Society Does Relativism

“What society does is right.”



- Whatever a society practices or accepts becomes right for that society.
- Morality changes from culture to culture and from one time period to another.
- No universal moral standards.

Examples

- “That’s just how their culture does it.”
- “Morality is whatever works for society.”
- Appeal to majority or tradition.
- What is common or accepted becomes right.

2 Society Says Relativism

“What society says is right.”



- Whatever the majority (or those in power) say is right, becomes right.
- Morality is determined by laws, consensus, or social constructs.
- Popular opinion becomes the ultimate authority.

Examples

- “If it’s legal, it’s moral.”
- “Science says ...”
- “The experts agree ...”
- “My professor says ...”
- Appeal to authority or consensus.
- Truth is whatever the culture, media, or government declares.

3 I Say Relativism

“What I say is right.”



- Each individual determines what is right or wrong for himself.
- “Truth is what works for me.”
- Complete subjectivity — no external standard.

Examples

- “That’s your truth, but not mine.”
- “I decide what’s right for me.”
- Emphasis on personal autonomy and feelings.
- What is true for you may be different for me.

They All Lead to the Same Place ...

- No objective truth
- No universal moral standards
- Confusion and contradiction
- A culture adrift

Yet We Still ...

- Condemn evil
- Praise good
- Demand justice
- Expect consistency
- Hold others accountable



“Everyone did what was right in his own eyes.”

Judges 21:25

**Different
Paths.
Same Dead End.**

The Seven Fatal Flaws

Relativism can't live up to its own claims.

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Relativism promises freedom, but delivers confusion.

1



No Basis for Accountability

If right and wrong are relative, no one is really to blame for anything. Praise and blame lose their meaning.

If morality is relative, no one is truly responsible.

2



Can't Condemn Evil

If morality is relative, things like genocide, racism, or child abuse are not truly wrong — just different.

If everything is relative, we can't call anything truly evil.

3



No Basis for Praise or Blame

If there are no objective moral standards, we can't meaningfully commend good behavior or criticize bad behavior.

If there is no right or wrong, praise and blame make no sense.

4



Undermines Justice

Justice requires a standard of right and wrong. Relativism removes the foundation for a just legal system.

Without objective truth, there can be no real justice.

5



No Moral Improvement

If all moral codes are equal, we can't say one society is morally better than another, or that we are making progress.

If all views are equal, there is no real progress — only change.

6



Makes Moral Discussion Impossible

If truth is only personal or cultural preference, rational discussion about morality becomes meaningless.

If truth is just a preference, there is no basis for real dialogue.

7



Leads to Intolerance

Ironically, those who claim “all views are equal” often marginalize and silence those who disagree.

Relativism often produces a culture that won't tolerate dissent.



“There are rules even within the framework that claims rules are relative.”

— Deep Dive Podcast

Truth Matters.
People Matter.
Speak with Clarity.

How to Answer Relativism

Practical ways to engage the conversation.

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You can engage with clarity, confidence, and respect.

1



Turn the Tables

Ask the relativist to live consistently with their own view.

- Point out the contradictions in their position.
- Show that they are making absolute claims (even while denying absolutes).

Sample Questions

- “So, if truth is relative, is that *statement really true for you?*”
- “Can we trust your belief that there are no absolute truths?”
- “Are some beliefs off-limits, or is everything equally valid?”

2



Press the Hot Button

Ask how they can condemn things like child abuse, genocide, or racism if there are no objective moral truths.

- Use clear, concrete examples.
- It exposes that they do, in fact, believe in real moral standards.

Sample Questions

- “If morality is relative, can we really say those things are wrong?”
- “Would it be wrong for a society to approve of child abuse?”
- “On what basis do you condemn genocide or racism?”

3



Force the Tolerance Issue

Show that relativism often leads to intolerance, as dissenting views are marginalized or silenced.

- Point out the irony; a view that claims tolerance often refuses to tolerate those who disagree.
- Ask if their view tolerates your right to hold a different opinion.

Sample Questions

- “Isn’t it intolerant to tell me I can’t claim there are absolute truths?”
- “Why is your view the only one tolerated in this conversation?”
- “If all views are equal, why aren’t my views given the same respect?”

4



Put the Burden of Proof Where It Belongs

Relativism makes a positive claim — that there are no objective moral truths.

- Ask for their justification and evidence.
- Don’t assume the burden to disprove relativism; make them defend it.

Sample Questions

- “What is your evidence that there are no absolute moral truths?”
- “How do you know your view is true?”
- “On what basis do you dismiss the possibility of objective truth?”
- “Why should I accept your claim that truth is relative?”



“Always be prepared to give an answer to everyone who asks you to give the reason for the hope that you have, but do this with gentleness and respect.” 1 Peter 3:15

Ask Well.
Listen Well.
Speak Truth in Love.

What Kind of Universe Does Morality Point To?

The features of moral law point beyond nature to a personal moral God.

Moral truth points beyond this world to a personal God.



“The Lord is righteous in all his ways ...”
Psalm 145:17

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1

Nonphysical

Moral laws are not material things.



- You can't see, touch, or measure them, yet they are real.
- They transcend the physical world.
- Moral truths are about how we ought to act, not about physical facts.

“Moral laws are not part of the material universe, but they are no less real.”

2

Communicative

Moral laws “speak” to us.



- They convey meaning, like a message from someone.
- They make sense of the world and human experience.
- Moral language is not just opinion — it communicates what is right and wrong.

“Moral laws are like a message — they tell us something.”

3

Obligatory

Moral laws make demands.



- They tell us what we ought to do, not just what we prefer.
- They carry real authority.
- We experience them as binding, even when it's inconvenient.

“Moral laws don't just suggest — they demand.”

4

Accompanied by Guilt

When we violate moral law, we experience guilt.



- Guilt is a sense that we have done something truly wrong.
- This points to a moral Judge, not a blind, impersonal universe.
- Guilt makes best sense if there is a personal, moral God.

“Our guilt makes sense only in a universe with a personal moral Judge.”



Objective moral truth makes sense in a world created by a personal moral God.

Truth Matters.
People Matter.
Point to the Source.